

'What makes you say that, Clement? What's in your mind? Out with it, man.'

'Why, nothing particular,' I said rather taken aback. 'Only—well, murder is in our minds just now. If by any chance you happened to discover the truth—I wondered how you would feel about it, that was all.'

His anger died down. He stared once more straight ahead of him, like a man trying to read the answer to a riddle that perplexes him, yet which exists only in his own brain.

'If I suspected—if I knew—I should do my duty, Clement. At least, I hope so.'

'The question is—which way would you consider your duty lay?'

He looked at me with inscrutable eyes.

'That question comes to every man some time in his life, I suppose, Clement. And every man has to decide it in his own way.'

'You don't know?'

'No, I don't know....'

I felt the best thing was to change the subject.

'That nephew of mine is enjoying this case thoroughly,' I said. 'Spends his entire time looking for footprints and cigarette ash.'

Haydock smiled.

'What age is he?'

'Just sixteen. You don't take tragedies seriously at that age. It's all Sherlock Holmes and Arsène Lupin to you.'

Haydock said thoughtfully:

'He's a fine looking boy. What are you going to do with him?'

'I can't afford a University education, I'm afraid. The boy himself wants to go into the Merchant Service. He failed for the Navy.'

'Well—it's a hard life—but he might do worse. Yes, he might do worse.'

'I must be going,' I exclaimed, catching sight of the clock. 'I'm nearly half an hour late for lunch.'

My family were just sitting down when I arrived. They demanded a full account of the morning's activities, which I gave them, feeling, as I did so, that most of it was in the nature of an anticlimax.

Dennis, however, was highly entertained by the history of Mrs Price Ridley's telephone call, and went into fits of laughter as I enlarged upon the

nervous shock her system had sustained and the necessity for reviving her with damson gin.

'Serve the old cat right,' he exclaimed. 'She's got the worst tongue in the place. I wish I'd thought of ringing her up and giving her a fright. I say, Uncle Len, what about giving her a second dose?'

I hastily begged him to do nothing of the sort. Nothing is more dangerous than the well-meant efforts of the younger generation to assist you and show their sympathy.

Dennis' mood changed suddenly. He frowned and put on his man-of-the-world air.

'I've been with Lettice most of the morning,' he said. 'You know, Griselda, she's really *very* worried. She doesn't want to show it, but she is. Very worried indeed.'

'I should hope so,' said Griselda with a toss of her head.

Griselda is not too fond of Lettice Protheroe.

'I don't think you're ever quite fair to Lettice.'

'Don't you?' said Griselda.

'Lots of people don't wear mourning.'

Griselda was silent and so was I. Dennis continued:

'She doesn't talk to most people, but she *does* talk to me. She's awfully worried about the whole thing, and she thinks something ought to be done about it.'

'She will find,' I said, 'that Inspector Slack shares her opinion. He is going up to Old Hall this afternoon, and will probably make the life of everybody there quite unbearable to them in his efforts to get at the truth.'

'What do you think *is* the truth, Len?' asked my wife suddenly.

'It's hard to say, my dear. I can't say that at the moment I've any idea at all.'

'Did you say that Inspector Slack was going to trace that telephone call—the one that took you to the Abbots?'

'Yes.'

'But can he do it? Isn't it a very difficult thing to do?'

'I should not imagine so. The exchange will have a record of the calls.'

'Oh! My wife relapsed into thought.'

'Uncle Len,' said my nephew. 'Why were you so ratty with me this morning for joking about your wishing Colonel Protheroe to be murdered?'

'Because,' I said, 'there is a time for everything. Inspector Slack has no sense of humour. He took your words quite seriously, will probably cross-examine Mary, and will get out a warrant for my arrest.'

'Doesn't he know when a fellow's ragging?'

'No,' I said. 'He does not. He has attained to his present position through hard work and zealous attention to duty. That has left him no time for the minor recreations of life.'

'Do you like him, Uncle Len?'

'No,' I said. 'I do not. From the first moment I saw him I disliked him intensely. But I have no doubt that he is a highly successful man in his profession.'

'You think he'll find out who shot old Protheroe?'

'If he doesn't,' I said, 'it will not be for the want of trying.'

Mary appeared and said:

'Mr Hawes wants to see you. I've put him in the drawing room, and here's a note. Waiting for an answer. Verbal will do.'

I tore open the note and read it.

Dear Mr Clement,

I should be so very grateful if you could come and see me this afternoon as early as possible. I am in great trouble and would like your advice.

Sincerely yours,

ESTELLE LESTRANGE.

'Say I will come round in about half an hour,' I said to Mary. Then I went into the drawing room to see Hawes.

'I've never heard you speak like this before.'

'I don't usually air my theories abroad. Today I'm riding my hobby. You're an intelligent man, Clement, which is more than some parsons are. You won't admit, I daresay, that there's no such thing as what is technically termed "Sin," but you're broad-minded enough to consider the possibility of such a thing.'

'It strikes at the root of all our accepted ideas,' I said.

'Yes, we're a narrow-minded, self-righteous lot, only too keen to judge matters we know nothing about. I honestly believe crime is a case for the doctor, not the policeman and not the parson. In the future, perhaps, there won't be any such thing.'

'You'll have cured it?'

'We'll have cured it. Rather a wonderful thought. Have you ever studied the statistics of crime? No—very few people have. I have, though. You'd be amazed at the amount there is of adolescent crime—glands again, you see. Young Neil, the Oxfordshire murderer, killed five little girls before he was suspected. Nice lad—never given any trouble of any kind. Lily Rose, the little Cornish girl, killed her uncle because he docked her of sweets. Hit him when he was asleep with a coal hammer. Went home and a fortnight later killed her elder sister who had annoyed her about some trifling matter. Neither of them hanged, of course. Sent to a home. May be all right later—may not. Doubt if the girl will. The only thing she cares about is seeing the pigs killed. Do you know when suicide is commonest? Fifteen to sixteen years of age. From self-murder to murder of someone else isn't a very long step. But it's not a moral lack—it's a physical one.'

'What you say is terrible!'

'No—it's only new to you. New truths have to be faced. One's ideas adjusted. But sometimes—it makes life difficult.'

He sat there frowning, yet with a strange look of weariness.

'Haydock,' I said, 'if you suspected—if you knew—that a certain person was a murderer, would you give that person up to the law, or would you be tempted to shield him?'

I was quite unprepared for the effect of my question. He turned on me angrily and suspiciously.

He roused himself with an effort.

'I meant to tell you about Hawes. All this business has driven him out of my mind.'

'Is he really ill?'

'There's nothing radically wrong with him. You know, of course, that he's had *Encephalitis Lethargica*—sleeping sickness, as it's commonly called?'

'No,' I said, very much surprised. 'I didn't know anything of the kind. He never told me anything about it. When did he have it?'

'About a year ago. He recovered all right—as far as one ever recovers. It's a strange disease—has a queer moral effect. The whole character may change after it.'

He was silent for a moment or two and then said:

'We think with horror now of the days when we burnt witches. I believe the day will come when we will shudder to think that we ever hanged criminals.'

'You don't believe in capital punishment?'

'It's not so much that.' He paused. 'You know,' he said slowly, 'I'd rather have my job than yours.'

'Why?'

'Because your job deals very largely with what we call right and wrong—and I'm not at all sure that there's any such thing. Suppose it's all a question of glandular secretion. Too much of one gland, too little of another—and you get your murderer, your thief, your habitual criminal. Clement, I believe the time will come when we'll be horrified to think of the long centuries in which we've indulged in what you may call moral reprobation, to think how we've punished people for disease—which they can't help, poor devils. You don't hang a man for having tuberculosis.'

'He isn't dangerous to the community.'

'In a sense he is. He infects other people. Or take a man who fancies he's the Emperor of China. You don't say "how wicked of him." I take your point about the community. The community must be protected. Shut up these people where they can't do any harm—even put them peacefully out of the way—yes, I'd go as far as that. But don't call it punishment. Don't bring shame on them and their innocent families.'

I looked at him curiously.

Chapter 15

HAWES' appearance distressed me very much. His hands were shaking and his face kept twitching nervously. In my opinion he should have been in bed, and I told him so. He insisted that he was perfectly well.

'I assure you, sir, I never felt better. Never in my life.'

This was so obviously wide of the truth that I hardly knew how to answer. I have a certain admiration for a man who will not give in to illness, but Hawes was carrying the thing rather too far.

'I called to tell you how sorry I was—that such a thing should happen in the Vicarage.'

'Yes,' I said. 'It's not very pleasant.'

'It's terrible—quite terrible. It seems they haven't arrested Mr Redding after all?'

'No. That was a mistake. He made—er—rather a foolish statement.'

'And the police are now quite convinced that he is innocent?'

'Perfectly.'

'Why is that, may I ask? Is it—I mean, do they suspect anyone else?'

I should never have suspected that Hawes would take such a keen interest in the details of a murder case. Perhaps it is because it happened in the Vicarage. He appeared as eager as a reporter.

'I don't know that I am completely in Inspector Slack's confidence. So far as I know he does not suspect anyone in particular. He is at present engaged in making inquiries.'

'Yes. Yes—of course. But who can one imagine doing such a dreadful thing?'

I shook my head.

'Colonel Protheroe was not a popular man, I know that. But murder! For murder—one would need a very strong motive.'

'So I should imagine,' I said.

'Who could have such a motive? Have the police any idea?'

'I couldn't say.'

'He might have made enemies, you know. The more I think about it, the more I am convinced that he was the kind of man to have enemies. He had a reputation on the Bench for being very severe.'

'I suppose he had.'

'Why, don't you remember, sir? He was telling you yesterday morning about having been threatened by that man, Archer.'

'Now I come to think of it, so he did,' I said. 'Of course, I remember. You were quite near us at the time.'

'Yes, I overheard what he was saying. Almost impossible to help it with Colonel Protheroe. He had such a very loud voice, hadn't he? I remember being impressed by your own words, that when his time came, he might have justice meted out to him instead of mercy.'

'Did I say that? I asked frowning. My remembrance of my own words was slightly different.

'You said it very impressively, sir. I was struck by your words. Justice is a terrible thing. And to think the poor man was struck down shortly afterwards. It's almost as though you had a premonition.'

'I had nothing of the sort,' I said shortly. I rather dislike Hawes' tendency to mysticism. There is a touch of the visionary about him.

'Have you told the police about this man Archer, sir?'

'I know nothing about him.'

'I mean, have you repeated to them what Colonel Protheroe said—about Archer having threatened him?'

'No,' I said slowly. 'I have not.'

'But you are going to do so?'

I was silent. I dislike hounding a man down who has already got the forces of law and order against him. I held no brief for Archer. He is an inveterate poacher—one of those cheerful ne'er-do-wells that are to be found in any parish. Whatever he may have said in the heat of anger when he was sentenced I had no definite knowledge that he felt the same when he came out of prison.

'You heard the conversation,' I said at last. 'If you feel it your duty to go to the police with it, you must do so.'

'It would come better from you, sir.'

Chapter 14



IN my way home, I ran into Miss Hartnell, and she detained me at least ten minutes, declaiming in her deep bass voice against the improvidence and ungratefulness of the lower classes. The crux of the matter seemed to be that The Poor did not want Miss Hartnell in their houses. My sympathies were entirely on their side. I am debarred by my social standing from expressing my prejudices in the forceful manner they do. I soothed her as best I could and made my escape.

Haydock overtook me in his car at the corner of the Vicarage road.

'I've just taken Mrs Protheroe home,' he called.

He waited for me at the gate of his house.

'Come in a minute,' he said.

I complied.

'This is an extraordinary business,' he said as he threw his hat on a chair and opened the door into his surgery.

He sank down on a shabby leather chair, and stared across the room.

He looked harried and perplexed.

I told him that we had succeeded in fixing the time of the shot. He listened with an almost abstracted air.

'That lets Anne Protheroe out,' he said. 'Well, well, I'm glad it's neither of those two. I like 'em both.'

I believed him, and yet it occurred to me to wonder why, since, as he said, he liked them both, their freedom from complicity seemed to have had the result of plunging him in gloom. This morning he had looked like a man with a weight lifted from his mind; now he looked thoroughly rattled and upset.

And yet I was convinced that he meant what he said. He was fond of both Anne Protheroe and Lawrence Redding. Why, then, this gloomy absorption?

'I see. So it took you—how long?'

'It's very nearly two miles, whichever way you go.'

'Through Old Hall woods is the shortest way, isn't it?'

'Actually, yes. But it's not particularly good going. I went and came back by the footpath across the fields.'

'The one that comes out opposite the Vicarage gate?'

'Yes.'

'And Mrs Clement?'

'My wife was in London. She arrived back by the 6.50 train.'

'Right. The maid I've seen. That finishes with the Vicarage. I'll be off to Old Hall next. And then I want an interview with Mrs Lestrangle. Queer her going to see Protheroe the night before he was killed. A lot of queer things about this case.'

I agreed.

Glancing at the clock, I realized that it was nearly lunch time. I invited Melchett to partake of pot luck with us, but he excused himself on the plea of having to go to the Blue Boar. The Blue Boar gives you a first-rate meal of the joint and two vegetable type. I thought his choice was a wise one. After her interview with the police, Mary would probably be feeling more temperamental than usual.

'Perhaps—but to tell the truth—well, I've no fancy for doing it. I might be helping to put the rope round the neck of an innocent man.'

'But if he shot Colonel Protheroe—'

'Oh! if! There's no evidence of any kind that he did.'

'His threats.'

'Strictly speaking, the threats were not his but Colonel Protheroe's. Colonel Protheroe was threatening to show Archer what vengeance was worth next time he caught him.'

'I don't understand your attitude, sir.'

'Don't you? I said wearily. 'You're a young man. You're zealous in the cause of right. When you get to my age, you'll find that you like to give people the benefit of the doubt.'

'It's not—I mean—'

He paused and I looked at him in surprise.

'You haven't any—any ideas of your own—as to the identity of the murderer, I mean?'

'Good heavens, no.'

Hawes persisted.

'Or as to the—the motive?'

'No. Have you?'

'? No, indeed. I just wondered. If Colonel Protheroe had—had confided in you in any way—mentioned anything...'

'His confidences, such as they were, were heard by the whole village street yesterday morning,' I said drily.

'Yes. Yes—of course. And you don't think—about Archer?'

'The police will know all about Archer soon enough,' I said. 'If I'd heard him threaten Colonel Protheroe myself, that would be a different matter. But you may be sure that if he actually has threatened him, half the people in the village will have heard him, and the news will get to the police all right. You, of course, must do as you like about the matter.'

But Hawes seemed curiously unwilling to do anything himself.

The man's whole attitude was nervous and queer. I recalled what Haydock had said about his illness. There, I supposed, lay the explanation. He took his leave unwillingly, as though he had more to say, and didn't know how to say it.

Before he left, I arranged with him to take the Service for the Mothers' Union followed by the Meeting of District Visitors. I had several projects of my own for the afternoon.

Dismissing Hawes and his troubles from my mind, I started off for Mrs Lestrangle.

On the table in the hall lay the 'Guardian' and the 'Church Times' unopened.

As I walked I remembered that Mrs Lestrangle had had an interview with Colonel Protheroe the night before his death. It was possible that something had transpired in that interview which would throw light upon the problem of his murder.

I was shown straight into the little drawing room, and Mrs Lestrangle rose to meet me. I was struck anew by the marvellous atmosphere that this woman could create. She wore a dress of some dead black material that showed off the extraordinary fairness of her skin. There was something curiously dead about her face. Only the eyes were burningly alive. There was a watchful look in them today. Otherwise she showed no signs of animation.

'It was very good of you to come, Mr Clement,' she said as she shook hands. 'I wanted to speak to you the other day. Then I decided not to do so. I was wrong.'

'As I told you then, I shall be glad to do anything that can help you.'

'Yes, you said that. And you said it as though you meant it. Very few people, Mr Clement, in this world have ever sincerely wished to help me.'

'I can hardly believe that, Mrs Lestrangle.'

'It is true. Most people—most men, at any rate, are out for their own hand.'

There was a bitterness in her voice.

I did not answer and she went on:

'Sit down, won't you?'

I obeyed, and she took a chair facing me. She hesitated a moment and then began to speak very slowly and thoughtfully, seeming to weigh each word as she uttered it.

'I am in a very peculiar position, Mr Clement, and I want to ask your advice. That is, I want to ask your advice as to what I should do next. What is past is past and cannot be undone. You understand?'

'Very strange things have been happening in this village lately,' she said, addressing herself to Melchett. 'Very strange things indeed. Colonel Protheroe was going to look into them, and what happened to him, poor man? Perhaps I shall be the next.'

And on that she took her departure, shaking her head with a kind of ominous melancholy. Melchett muttered under his breath, 'No such luck.' Then his face grew grave, and he looked inquiringly at Inspector Slack.

That worthy nodded his head slowly.

'This about settles it, sir. That's three people who heard the shot. We've got to find out now who fired it. This business of Mr Redding's has delayed us. But we've got several starting points. Thinking Mr Redding was guilty, I didn't bother to look into them. But that's all changed now. And now one of the first things to do is to look up that telephone call.'

'Mrs Price Ridley's?'

The Inspector grinned.

'No—though I suppose we'd better make a note of that or else we shall have the old girl bothering in here again. No, I meant that fake call that got the Vicar out of the way.'

'Yes,' said Melchett. 'That's important.'

'And the next thing is to find out what everyone was doing that evening between six and seven. Everyone at Old Hall, I mean, and pretty well everyone in the village as well.'

I gave a sigh.

'What wonderful energy you have, Inspector Slack.'

'I believe in hard work. We'll begin by just noting down your own movements, Mr Clement.'

'Willingly. The telephone call came through about half past five.'

'A man's voice, or a woman's?'

'A woman's. At least it sounded like a woman's. But of course I took it for granted it was Mrs Abbott speaking.'

'You didn't recognize it as being Mrs Abbott's?'

'No, I can't say I did. I didn't notice the voice particularly, or think about it.'

'And you started right away? Walked? Haven't you got a bicycle?'

'No.'

"*Unless you hold your tongue in future, it will be the worse for you—in more ways than one.*" I can't describe to you the menacing way that was said. I gasped "Who are you?" faintly—like that, and the voice answered, "*The Avenger.*" I gave a little shriek; it sounded so awful, and then—the person laughed. Laughed! Distinctly. And that was all. I heard him hang up the receiver. Of course I asked the exchange what number had been ringing me up, but they said they didn't know. You know what exchanges are. Thoroughly rude and unsympathetic."

"Quite," I said.

"I felt quite faint," continued Mrs Price Ridley. "All on edge and so nervous that when I heard a shot in the woods I do declare I jumped almost out of my skin. That will show you."

"A shot in the woods," said Inspector Slack alertly.

"In my excited state, it simply sounded to me like a cannon going off."

"Oh!" I said, and sank down on the sofa in a state of prostration. Clara had to bring me a glass of damson gin."

"Shocking," said Melchett. "Shocking. All very trying for you. And the shot sounded very loud, you say? As though it were near at hand?"

"That was simply the state of my nerves."

"Of course. Of course. And what time was all this? To help us in tracing the telephone call, you know."

"About half past six."

"You can't give it us more exactly than that?"

"Well, you see, the little clock on my mantelpiece had just chimed the half hour, and I said "Surely that clock is fast." (It does gain, that clock.) And I compared it with the watch I was wearing and that only said ten minutes past, but then I put it to my ear and found it had stopped. So I thought, "Well, if that clock is fast, I shall hear the church tower in a moment or two." And then, of course, the telephone bell rang, and I forgot all about it."

She paused, breathless.

"Well, that's near enough," said Colonel Melchett. "We'll have it looked into for you, Mrs Price Ridley."

"Just think of it as a silly joke, and don't worry, Mrs Price Ridley," I said. She looked at me coldly. Evidently the incident of the pound note still rankled.

Before I could reply, the maid who had admitted me opened the door and said, with a scared face:

"Oh! please, m'am, there's a police inspector here, and he says he must speak to you, please."

There was a pause. Mrs Lestrangle's face did not change. Only her eyes very slowly closed and opened again. She seemed to swallow once or twice, then she said in exactly the same clear, calm voice:

"Show him in, Hilda."

I was about to rise, but she motioned me back again with an imperious hand.

"If you do not mind—I should be much obliged if you would stay."

I resumed my seat.

"Certainly, if you wish it," I murmured, as Slack entered with a brisk regulation tread.

"Good afternoon, Madam," he began.

"Good afternoon, Inspector."

At this moment he caught sight of me and scowled. There is no doubt about it; Slack does not like me.

"You have no objection to the Vicar's presence, I hope?"

I suppose that Slack could not very well say he had.

"No-o," he said grudgingly. "Though, perhaps, it might be better—"

Mrs Lestrangle paid no attention to the hint.

"What can I do for you, Inspector?" she asked.

"It's this way, Madam. Murder of Colonel Protheroe. I'm in charge of the case and making inquiries."

Mrs Lestrangle nodded.

"Just as a matter of form, I'm asking everyone just where they were yesterday evening between the hours of six and seven. Just as a matter of form, you understand."

Mrs Lestrangle did not seem in the least discomposed.

"You want to know where I was yesterday evening between six and seven?"

"If you please, Madam."

"Let me see." She reflected a moment. "I was here. In this house."

"Oh! I saw the Inspector's eyes flash. 'And your maid—you have only one maid, I think, can confirm that statement?'"

'No, it was Hilda's afternoon out.'

'I see.'

'So unfortunately you will have to take my word for it,' said Mrs Lestrangle pleasantly.

'You seriously declare that you were at home all the afternoon?'

'You said between six and seven, Inspector. I was out for a walk earlier in the afternoon. I returned some time before five o'clock.'

'Then if a lady—Miss Hartnell, for instance—were to declare that she came here about six o'clock, rang the bell, but could make no one hear and was compelled to go away again, you'd say she was mistaken, eh?'

'Oh! no,' Mrs Lestrangle shook her head.

'But—'

'If your maid is in, she can say not at home. If one is alone and does not happen to want to see callers—well, the only thing to do is to let them ring.'

Inspector Slack looked slightly baffled.

'Elderly women bore me dreadfully,' said Mrs Lestrangle. 'And Miss Hartnell is particularly boring. She must have rung at least half a dozen times before she went away.'

She smiled sweetly at Inspector Slack.

The Inspector shifted his ground.

'Then if anyone were to say they'd seen you out and about then—'

'Oh! but they didn't, did they?' She was quick to sense his weak point.

'No one saw me out, because I was in, you see.'

'Quite so, Madam.'

The Inspector hitched his chair a little nearer.

'Now I understand, Mrs Lestrangle, that you paid a visit to Colonel Protheroe at Old Hall the night before his death.'

Mrs Lestrangle said calmly:

'That is so.'

'Can you indicate to me the nature of that interview?'

'It concerned a private matter, Inspector.'

'I'm afraid I must ask you to tell me the nature of that private matter.'

'I shall not tell you anything of the kind. I will only assure you that nothing which was said at that interview could possibly have any bearing upon the crime.'

'It wasn't that kind of thing,' said Mrs Price Ridley. 'At first, I must admit, I was quite taken in. I thought it was a genuine message. Then the—er—person became abusive.'

'Abusive?'

'Most abusive. I was quite alarmed.'

'Used threatening language, eh?'

'Yes. I am not accustomed to being threatened.'

'What did they threaten you with? Bodily damage?'

'Not exactly.'

'I'm afraid, Mrs Price Ridley, you must be more explicit. In what way were you threatened?'

This Mrs Price Ridley seemed singularly reluctant to answer.

'I can't remember exactly. It was all so upsetting. But right at the end—when I was really *very* upset, this—this—*wretch* laughed.'

'Was it a man's voice or a woman's?'

'It was a degenerate voice,' said Mrs Price Ridley with dignity. 'I can only describe it as a kind of perverted voice. Now gruff, now squeaking. Really a very *peculiar* voice.'

'Probably a practical joke,' said the Colonel soothingly.

'A most wicked thing to do, if so. I might have had a heart attack.'

'We'll look into it,' said the Colonel. 'Eh, Inspector? Trace the telephone call. You can't tell me more definitely exactly what was said, Mrs Price Ridley?'

A struggle began in Mrs Price Ridley's ample black bosom. The desire for reticence fought against a desire for vengeance. Vengeance triumphed.

'This, of course, will go no farther,' she began.

'Of course not.'

'This creature began by saying—I can hardly bring myself to repeat it—'

'Yes, yes,' said Melchett encouragingly.

'"*You are a wicked, scandal-mongering old woman!*" Me, Colonel Melchett—a scandal-mongering old woman. "*But this time you've gone too far. Scotland Yard are after you for libel.*"'

'Naturally, you were alarmed,' said Melchett, biting his moustache to conceal a smile.